THE PRACTICAL MINI GUIDE

Starting a business in Austria

Gewerbeanmeldung, qualifications, permission to operate and social insurance.



Inside this guide

Check the right to undertake this specific activity / Distinguish trades, regulated activities and other professions / Organise taxes, records and social insurance together

GOOD TO KNOW

01 Check the right to undertake this specific activity

Start with your actual residence document and the activity you intend to offer. EU, EEA and Swiss citizens and people from third countries have different legal starting points. Displaced Ukrainians should verify the rules applicable to their document rather than relying on nationality or assuming that employee access settles every business requirement. Ask the competent authority or a qualified start-up adviser how your situation affects the planned activity before signing binding contracts.

02 Distinguish trades, regulated activities and other professions

Activities covered by the Austrian Gewerbeordnung generally require trade registration with the competent authority at the business location. A free trade and a regulated trade are not the same: regulated trades require evidence of professional competence or the applicable alternative authorisation. Some independent professional activities fall under other frameworks instead of ordinary trade registration. Do not transfer the German Freiberufler classification to Austria without checking the actual Austrian rules.

GOOD TO KNOW

03 Organise taxes, records and social insurance together

Ask which tax registration, declarations and invoicing requirements apply to the chosen activity and legal form. Small scale does not automatically remove every tax or record-keeping obligation. Clarify social-insurance responsibilities with the appropriate institution; SVS is relevant for many self-employed people. Check when reporting and coverage obligations begin. Retain invoices, separate business records from personal spending and allow for future tax and insurance payments.

04 Use official advice and build a relevant local network

Use the Austrian Business Service Portal, USP, to follow the steps for your activity and locate the relevant authority. A regional WKO start-up service can help clarify trade classification and point you to appropriate business advice. Use founder events and community contacts to understand customer needs and find collaborators.

Common questions

Does a free trade mean that no registration is required?

No. In this context, a free trade is distinguished from a regulated trade by the competence requirements. An activity subject to the trade rules still requires the appropriate registration. Confirm the classification and the conditions for your specific activity before starting.

Can I use Germany’s Freiberufler rules for an Austrian business?

No. Austria has its own trade and professional frameworks. Some activities fall outside ordinary trade registration, but the classification must be checked under Austrian rules. Describe the actual services and obtain guidance from the competent authority or qualified adviser rather than choosing a label.

Can I assume the residence card resolves tax and insurance registration?

No. Residence permission, trade or professional registration, tax obligations and social insurance are different matters. Clarify each step and the date when it applies. Keep written answers and include the expected obligations in your budget before accepting your first paid work.

Sources and useful links

Unternehmensserviceportal — Gewerbeanmeldung

Sozialministerium — Work and Migration

Stadt Wien — health system in Austria

The procedure depends on residence documentation, activity and location. The primary sources below help clarify the requirements for your circumstances.

Explore more on Sweezy